

WORKED EXAMPLE

Jack Mo reads it aloud

MEP above ceilings

THE UNTRAINED EYE vs THE RISK MANAGER'S EYE



Jack Mo circles what his eye lands on — and the one thing that should be there and isn't.

To an ordinary eye, this overhead is finished work — a tidy ribbon of silver ducts, copper pipe, gray conduit and a cable tray, all tucked neatly above the ceiling grid. It looks done. Lights will go in, tiles will close it up, and nobody will ever look here again. A risk manager tilts their head back and feels the plenum shrink. They don't see four systems resting in their lanes; they see four systems racing for the same few inches, and they start tracing. Follow the big duct, then follow the sprinkler main, and watch where the two lines want to occupy one point in space. That intersection is where the drawings either did the coordination or quietly passed it to the field. The casual eye reads neatness and moves on to the next room. The trained eye reads neatness and asks whether anyone reconciled these systems before the bid, what a late tenant change would reshuffle up here, and which piece both subs assumed the other would hang. One reading sees a ceiling almost ready to close. The other sees the RFI, the change order and the rework already waiting in that shallow gap, plus the part nobody bought because two scopes both excluded it. Same ducts. Same pipes. Same photograph. The scene did not change between those two readings. The eye did.

THIS SCENE FEEDS YOUR REGISTER

R20 • R24 • R28 • R32 • R36 — the five students dealt this scene.

The discipline under that read

The moves you run so you can see it too — then five register rows fall out of one glance.

- LOOK**
SPLIT
NOTICE
ASK → PROJECT
- sweep overhead → working level → ground/openings → edges → background (don't lock on the obvious).
say what you SEE — facts only: Ducts, pipes, conduit and a cable tray all share one shallow plenum above the ceiling line, Trace any two systems and they converge toward the same few inches of overhead space, The ceiling grid is hung and ready to close, fixing whatever is above it in place.
circle the cues: The point where a duct and a pipe both reach for the same few inches; The shallow depth of the plenum against everything packed into it; The hung ceiling grid waiting to close it all up — and the missing No coordination signature anywhere overhead — no clash-resolved reroutes, no sequencing tags, no sign that one party owns the order in which these systems were installed. The missing thing is proof that someone reconciled all four systems on paper before they ever met in this plenum.
what releases it, who's in the path, what happens next — and in which phase.

NAME · five rows, born from one glance (cause → event → consequence)

- 1

MEP clashes
Because the duct, pipe, conduit and tray were never reconciled to one set of coordinated drawings, two trades may arrive to claim the same few inches of plenum, leading to an RFI, a change order and rework to reroute one of them.
Owner: MEP Coordinator · Trigger: two systems sharing the same elevation at a crossing on the overhead coordination drawing
- 2

Incomplete design
Because the documents were only partly finished at bid, more uncoordinated gaps may surface as installation reaches each overhead zone, leading to a stream of RFIs and change orders that drag out cost and schedule.
- 3

Owner changes
Because a tenant can revise its fit-out after the layout is set, the whole overhead arrangement may have to be reshuffled late, leading to tear-out of installed systems and rework against an already-fixed ceiling.
- 4

Scope gaps
Because two subs each excluded the same piece of work, nobody may install that connection, leading to an incomplete system discovered late and emergency work to assign and close the gap.
- 5

Sequencing
Because every trade needs the same shallow plenum and the install order was never set, a later trade may find its path already blocked by work in place, leading to removal and reinstallation that costs time and quality.

READING MOVE · bank this card
“In any tight overhead space, pick two systems and follow them until they meet — the point where they reach for the same few inches is where uncoordinated design turns into your RFI, change order and rework.”

SUCCESS CARD · check the read against these six

- ☐ a real, visible cue

☐ cause is a site condition

☐ a future event

☐ consequence on cost/time/quality/safety
- ☐ owner + early-warning trigger

☐ (M4) P and I each defended